have to understand the troika of jal, jungle and jameen (water, forest and land), which is central to tribal lives, to truly understand India. Rahul explained how ‘Adivasi’ is a term of pride, since it marks them as the original dwellers, and hence the owners of the country. However, by reducing them to ‘vanvasi’, or mere forest dwellers, the BJP is reducing their birthright and paving the road for their displacement. Rahul then went on to explain how the Indian Prime Minister had misused this ontological distinction to indiscriminately displace tribals from forest lands and distribute tens of thousands of forests to select crony capitalists. Rahul explained the complex politics behind the use of vanvasi and its devastating effects in a touching and frankly very effective manner. So I reiterate—Rahul may not be bombastic or a performative orator, but he is an effective and sincere one. And unlike what the media suggests, people do respond to him. I often think that it was not he who was reduced to a pappu (simpleton) by the BJP, but us, the people of India.

After the interactions, the Yatra would again resume at about 3 p.m. and continue until about 7 p.m. every day, when the Congress would organize a corner meeting with local residents. This entire operation ran like clockwork. The Congress had a set of doctors and paramedics available on standby. Lalji Desai, the Seva Dal in-charge, had conducted workshops for yatris to ensure discipline and timely execution of all the logistics of the Yatra. Separately, the social media team was working overtime to ensure that everyone who came to meet Rahul Gandhi was separately interviewed, while interactions (both sitting and walking) were photographed. The Congress undoubtedly had help in the form of an external agency named Teen Bandar. This work (like everything else) should ideally have been done in-house, given it has so many young, tech-savvy people inside the organization. All of these videos and photos were uploaded by the end of each day for all of us to access (through a QR code on a card that we were given). Given the media’s blackout, it effectively meant that anyone who joined the Yatra or met Rahul Gandhi would invariably share it on their social media accounts—Facebook, Instagram and Twitter—and the Yatra would automatically get wider coverage. Even the logistics of the civil